

Breath Guide

Four techniques, when to use each, the one-minute practice, and a log · Module 4, Training 2

Why the breath

Long, slow exhales press the brake of the nervous system (the parasympathetic branch, via the vagus nerve). Slow breathing at about six breaths a minute increased heart-rate variability and reduced anxiety across studies (Zaccaro et al., *Frontiers in Human Neuroscience*). Five minutes a day of cyclic sighing improved mood more than the same time in mindfulness (Balban et al., *Cell Reports Medicine*, Stanford). Harvard Health recommends slow deep breathing as the fastest route to the relaxation response (Benson).

Safety: the holds are optional; the slow exhale is the point. Dizzy? Return to normal breathing and make the breaths smaller. Pregnant, or a heart or respiratory condition? Use six-a-minute (no holds) and ask your doctor.

The four techniques

TECHNIQUE	PATTERN	ROUNDS	BEST FOR
Physiological sigh	inhale through the nose · small second sip · one long exhale through the mouth	1–3	the fastest reset: a text, a craving, before you answer in an argument
Box breathing	in 4 · hold 4 · out 4 · hold 4 (picture the square)	4 squares	waiting rooms, the car before an appointment, spinning thoughts
4-7-8 (Weil)	in through the nose 4 · hold 7 · out through the mouth 8 with a soft whoosh	4	falling asleep
Six-a-minute	in 5 · out 5, no holds	2 minutes	the gentlest; riding out a craving; anyone who dislikes holds

Diagrams

Box: □ trace one side per count — up (in 4) → across (hold 4) → down (out 4) → across (hold 4). **Sigh:** Λ Λ → — two short ups, one long down. **4-7-8:** ↑4 117 ↓8. **Six-a-minute:** ~ a slow wave, five up, five down.

The one-minute practice (from the video)

1. Two physiological sighs.

2. Two box squares.
3. Two rounds of six-a-minute.

When to use which

MOMENT	REACH FOR
Two-week wait, negative test, the scan	sigh ×3, then box
A craving (Modules 1–2): most urges pass within ~20 minutes	six-a-minute for 2 minutes
Before a call or appointment	box, in the car
Mid-disagreement (Module 6)	one sigh before you answer
Can't sleep (Module 4, T6)	4-7-8 ×4, lights off
With your partner	six-a-minute back to back on the bed

Try three techniques (30 XP)

TECHNIQUE	DATE	WHERE	FELT AFTER 1–10	KEEP IT?
Physiological sigh				☐
Box breathing				☐
4-7-8				☐
Six-a-minute				☐

Use one in real stress (40 XP)

My anchor moment (drive, wait, after dinner, bedtime): _____ My technique:

DATE	WHAT HAPPENED	TECHNIQUE	FEELING BEFORE 1– 10	ONE MINUTE LATER 1– 10	NOTES

My technique (the one I come back to): _____

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Educational content only, not medical advice. Always consult your doctor or a qualified health professional before changing supplements, diet, exercise or detox practices, especially while trying to conceive.